

FIELD NOTES

2002-75

Species reported: Iceland Gull- 1st alternate plumage (video included)

Number of individuals: one

Location: Prince Lake #2-eastern Boulder County

Date of sighting: 04/09/00 – 04/19/00, however this description will be based predominately from the April 19 observation. The bird was first seen briefly by Peter and I on April 2

Time: Various times throughout the day

Reporting observer: John W. Vanderpoel
7583 Estate Circle
Niwot, CO 80503

Other observers: Peter Gent & Tony Leukering.

Light and weather conditions: Cloudy/high cloud ceiling with good visibility and cool in the low 50's; Strong winds out of the west.

Optical Equipment: Zeiss 10 X 40B, Kowa Telescope

Distance to bird: range 50 yards- 200 yards.

Description:

size - This individual was smaller than many Iceland Gulls I've seen; only very slightly larger than the surrounding California Gulls, though somewhat longer legged. It was considerably smaller than the Herring Gulls it frequently stood near and also appeared to be smaller than any of the seven Thayer's Gulls that were around it either at Prince Lake or the Erie Dump. When seen in flight among the group of California Gulls it again was visibly larger, but only slightly so though the wings were wider at the base.

general appearance- The bird was overall whitish in appearance flecked with buff barring general in the shape of arrows which were strongest on the belly

head - rounder than the Herring Gulls and most of the Thayer's it was with. The eyes were dark.

bill - Structurally the bill was considerably shorter than the bills of the surrounding California Gulls and no thicker. The color was black at the tip and blended towards a pale flesh at the base; but the separation was not sharply demarcated.

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legs - blackish

chest and belly -

coverts -not noted

tertials.- were faded from wear, but the centers were not solid (like Thayer's), but instead had internal loops and markings.

tail - was whitish and uniform with the rest of the bird. I could not really see any tailband, certainly not a prominent one.

folded primaries - the tips were pure white, paler even than the rest of the bird.

mantle - The mantle was whitish and did not yet show any gray.

scapulars - . The scapulars were flecked with darker barring, which created a darker diagonal ridge on the back (see video)

Flight Discussion: Seen in flight with the similarly long winged California Gulls, the base of the wing was wider, but that really doesn't mean anything at all.

Voice: N/A

Previous Experience: I've seen and filmed close to a thousand Iceland Gulls of all ages in Ohio, Niagara Falls and Newfoundland.

Identification Aids: (list of books, illustrations, video or other birders consulted in identification)

at time of observation - none

after observation - none

Similar Species to consider - Similar species would be Glaucous and Thayer's Gull.

- 1) Glaucous Gull - These two species have almost identical 1st basic/alternate plumages. However, there is no overlap in size between these two species and the small overall size and the bill size, shape and color helped rule out Glaucous Gull as well as the long winged look discussed earlier.
- 2) Thayer's Gull - By April 1st year Thayer's Gulls have become very pale, due in part to wear and the bleaching effect of the sun. The California Records

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Committee has been very conservative when reviewing all potential Iceland Gulls particularly in March & April. However the particularly small size, white primary tips, lack of tailband and irregularly marked tertial centers all help to eliminate Thayer's Gull

Conclusion: The bird was a 1st alternate Iceland Gull.



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Record Information (Edit Submission)

Iceland Gull (*Larus glaucooides*)
Date of Observation: 04/18/2000
Submitted By: Tony Leukering

Accession Number: unassigned
Submitted: January 17, 2006, 15:33:04
Record Status: submitted

Submitted By

Tony Leukering
PO Box 660
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Other Observers: John Vanderpoel (who took video of the bird), Rich Levad
Original and/or Independent Observers: The bird was first found by John Vanderpoel and Peter Gent at Prince Res. #2 in Boulder Co. on the 9th of April and John put the definitive name to the bird on the 18th.

Bird Information

Sex: unknown

Plumage: First Basic

Call or Song: none heard

Description: An immature gull somewhat similar to nearby First Basic Thayer's Gull, but much paler and without the darker primaries of that taxon. The bill was quite short and mostly black, but with a pale base, mostly on the mandible. The wings extended well past the tail tip with the tip of P7 falling just short of the tail. The primaries on the folded wing were fringed very widely with white, but because of the paleness of the primaries, the wide fringes made the primaries look white; they were very wide (much wider than found on Thayer's Gulls of the same age).

The tertials were white with a few brown bars and without a solid dark center. The legs were short and bright pink. The tail was darker than the rump, which was the palest part of the upperparts, being nearly white. The underparts were a creamy white with a variety of small darker splotches.

Behaviors: Foraging in landfill

Number of Birds: 1

Record Information**County:** Weld**Nearest Town:** Erie**Exact Location:** Erie landfill north of Hwy 7**Elevation:****First Date of Observation:** 04/18/2000**Time of Observation:** early morning**Length of Observation:** about 12 minutes**Other Dates of Observation and Information:****Light Conditions:** Excellent, with blue sky and sun behind me**Optics Used:** Leica 32x**Distance to Bird:** Estimated closest approach at ~ 35 meters**Habitat:** urban landfill**Similar Species:** Thayer's Gulls of similar age are the most similar species, but details of the tertial pattern and the very pale coloration rule out that taxon.**Resources Used for ID:** none**Prior Experience:** I have seen >25 immature Iceland Gulls and 100s of similarly-aged Thayer's Gulls**Report Type:** This report was made from notes made AFTER observation**Comments:** I wrote notes about 2 hours after sighting. This occurrence already has an accession number due to John Vanderpoel's submission back in 2000.

Media Information**Photographed:** yes**Submitting Photos:** no

This Record does not have any images.